

PAPUA NEW GUINEA

FEWER THAN SIX MILLION PEOPLE live in Papua New Guinea, most of them in small, isolated villages. By western standards, many people are poor. Papua is rich in natural resources, especially minerals, such as copper, gold, nickel, and cobalt. It also has extensive oil and natural gas reserves. Lumber from the rain forests is another major export. The challenge is to develop these resources without damaging the environment.



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Capital city: Port Moresby

Area: 178,703 sq miles (462,840 sq km)

Population: 5,700,000

Official language: English

Major religions: Christian 62%, traditional beliefs 34%, other 4%

Government: Multiparty democracy

Currency: Kina

Adult literacy rate: 65%

Life expectancy: 57 years

People per doctor: 10,000

Televisions: 24 per 1,000 people



BIG BUTTERFLY
Queen Alexandra's Birdwing butterfly, with a wingspan of 10 in (25 cm), is the world's largest butterfly.



TRIBAL PEOPLE

The mountains and forests of Papua New Guinea have always restricted contact between the various groups of people

who live there. As a result, the country is now home to about 1,000 tribes speaking more than 700 different languages. Most of these people live off the land they farm.



PORT MORESBY

The capital, Port Moresby, is a sprawling city built around a natural harbor on the island's southern coast. Unlike the rest of the country, it is dry for much of the year. Port Moresby has grown rapidly in recent years, as people from remote regions have moved there to find work.

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